MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 1: Socio-political Background

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

England changed through conquest, disease, rebellion, new learning, and religious conflict, and these changes shaped its literature.

Start with a picture

Imagine a village where a few people own nearly all the land. Most people work for them. Books are copied by hand, and the Church has great influence. Now imagine new rulers arriving, workers demanding better treatment, and printed books spreading new ideas. This is the changing world behind the poems and plays you will study.

Learn it step by step

1. The Norman Conquest: new rulers, new words

In 1066, William of Normandy defeated Harold at the Battle of Hastings. The new ruling class used French, while ordinary people continued to speak English. Latin remained important in religion and learning. Over time, contact between these languages helped reshape English.

Think of a school where newcomers bring another language: people gradually borrow words from one another. The conquest did not invent English; it changed an existing language and its social position.

2. Feudalism: land in exchange for service

Under feudal arrangements, land, loyalty, military service, and labour connected kings, nobles, and peasants. This was an unequal system. Its decline was gradual, helped by economic change, stronger central government, and changes in labour relationships.

3. The Crusades: religion, travel, and money

The Crusades were military campaigns connected with Christian attempts to control holy places. They also increased contact with other societies and encouraged trade. Financing campaigns placed burdens on people through taxation. Remember both belief and material consequences.

4. The Black Death: fewer workers, changing power

The plague devastated England from 1348. With fewer surviving workers, labour became more valuable. Landowners and authorities tried to control wages and movement. This helped produce social tension.

An everyday comparison: if only a few people can do an essential job, their work becomes harder to replace.

5. The Peasants' Revolt: ordinary people resist

In 1381, anger over taxation, labour restrictions, and unequal treatment led to revolt. Wat Tyler was a major leader. The revolt was suppressed, but it revealed that peasants could organise and challenge authority. It did not immediately end inequality.

6. The Wars of the Roses: a struggle for the crown

The houses of Lancaster and York fought for royal power. Henry Tudor's victory in 1485 helped establish the Tudor dynasty. Political insecurity matters because literature often explores authority, succession, and disorder.

7. Renaissance and humanism: learning expands

Renaissance means a revival of interest in classical learning and the arts. **Humanism** emphasised education, language, reason, and human capacities through the study of classical texts. Humanism was not simply the rejection of religion; many humanists were religious.

8. Reformation: religious authority is challenged

The Reformation changed Western Christianity. In England, Henry VIII's break with Rome and later religious changes affected government, worship, education, and writing. This was a complex process, not one single event.

9. Printing, education, and sea travel

William Caxton established a printing press at Westminster in 1476. Printing made repeated copies easier to produce, although books were not instantly cheap or available to everyone. Education and maritime expansion widened English horizons. Overseas expansion also involved conquest and exploitation.

Remember these words

- **Feudalism:** relationships organised around land and service.
- **Humanism:** learning centred on human capacities and classical texts.
- **Reformation:** movements that reshaped religious institutions and beliefs.
- **Maritime:** connected with the sea.

Build an exam answer

For "How did social changes influence literature?", choose three changes. Explain each change, its effect on people, and its literary relevance. For example: printing → wider circulation of texts → more opportunities to encounter new ideas.

Quick check

1. Did the Norman Conquest create English from nothing? **No; it transformed an existing language.**
2. Why did plague affect workers' bargaining power? **A shortage made their labour more valuable.**
3. Were Renaissance and Reformation identical? **No; one concerns cultural and intellectual renewal, the other religious change, although they overlap.**

Memory line

New rulers → social pressure → new learning → religious change → wider circulation of ideas.

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

How did historical change prepare the ground for new English literature?

Expanded discussion

The development of English literature must be understood alongside changes in language and social power. After the Norman Conquest, French enjoyed the prestige of the ruling class, while English continued among much of the population. Contact among English, French, and Latin widened linguistic resources. The eventual rise of English as a literary language therefore reflects cultural negotiation rather than a sudden replacement of one language by another. Chaucer's achievement belongs within this longer development.

Economic and political changes also altered how people understood authority. The Black Death reduced the labouring population, making labour scarce and intensifying conflict over wages and service. The Peasants' Revolt demonstrated resistance to unequal obligations even though it was suppressed. These developments help readers understand why work, rank, religious duty, and the behaviour of powerful people become important subjects of literary observation and satire.

Renaissance humanism encouraged the study of classical languages, rhetoric, history, and moral philosophy. Its emphasis on education and human capacities created new resources for literary invention. Religious reformation, meanwhile, made questions of conscience and authority especially urgent. Printing enabled texts to circulate more widely, although access still depended on wealth, literacy, and location. These changes were interconnected, but none alone explains the entire literary transformation.

Suggested answer structure

1. Language and conquest
2. Social pressure and labour
3. Renaissance learning
4. Religious change and printing

5. Literature as a response to changing conditions

Common mistakes to avoid

Avoid listing events without explaining their effects. Do not claim that printing immediately produced universal literacy.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.